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Ministry of Peshmerga Affairs: Dijila Operations Command retreats from Kirkuk

Erbil, Kurdistan (KRG.org) – Lieutenant General Jabbar Yawar, Secretary-General of the KRG Ministry of Peshmerga Affairs and the Spokesperson of the Region's armed forces, stated that Peshmerga forces now control Kirkuk city after the Dijila Operations Command retreated from its position. He said, "Peshmerga forces are in control of the majority of the Kurdistan Region outside of KRG administration."

The Dijila Operations Command is part of the Iraqi Army under the direct supervision of Prime Minister Nouri Maliki and was deployed in 2012 in and around disputed territories. It has been a source of tension between Erbil and Baghdad since its establishment.

In a statement to KRG.org, Jabbar Yawar pointed out that the KRG has in the past issued warnings that such events would occur in Mosul and parts of Iraq, particularly given the surge of terrorist activities in these areas. He said, "Especially in Ninewa, Salahaddin and Anbar governorates, the Iraqi security agencies and ministries have been incapable and soldiers and employees were only interested in collecting their salaries." He added that the collapse of these forces after their first engagement in battle had been predicted, but "Baghdad did not heed the KRG's warnings and now, unfortunately, our predictions have come to pass."

The Lieutenant General explained that during a number of military meetings between KRG and federal government delegations, the KRG proposed that "several military bases be built in Anbar, Salahaddin and Mosul – particularly at the desert border areas – but Baghdad incorrectly interpreted our proposals as politically motivated and not in the public's interest."

Yawar recalled that at the end of 2012, Peshmerga forces drew a line designed to protect the Kurdistan Region, including the areas of "Naftkhana, Khanaqin, Jalawla, Saadiya, Qaratapa, south and west of Tuz Khurmatu, and south and west of Kirkuk. This is in addition to the areas of Dibagah, Makhmour and as far as Fishkhabour. This line, which is 1050 kilometres in length, has been protected by the Kurdistan Region's 70th and 80th forces, rapid-response units, Asayish, and Zeravani. Over the past several days, as the Iraqi Army has abandoned its posts, including joint-force positions, Peshmerga reinforcements have been dispatched to fill their places."

Yawar also revealed that Peshmerga are present in "Gwer and the areas surrounding Kirkuk city, including Taza Khurmatu and areas close to Hawija and Dibis." To make these areas more secure, he reiterated that the Kurdistan Region remains open for all people fleeing their homes because of the threat of terror. "The Peshmerga will help them in every way that they can. In the meantime, security measures taken by Peshmerga forces will not cause conflict or disruption for citizens living in these areas."

The Lieutenant General explained that no confrontation has taken place between the Peshmerga forces and the Iraqi Army. He said, "Peshmerga forces have helped Iraqi soldiers and military leaders when they abandoned their positions. We helped them to reach Baghdad via the Kurdistan Region, particularly three Iraqi military leaders: General Ali Ghaidan, General Abood Qambar, and Lieutenant-General Muhsin Mahmud, as well as the two pilots who abandoned their planes. They were all sent back to Baghdad via Erbil International Airport."

Jabar Yawar also clarified that Peshmerga forces quickly reached the Rabia border crossing in order to establish military positions to secure the border area.

He emphasized that "no Dijila Operations Command soldiers are present in the city of Kirkuk, and all the units of the Iraqi Army's 12th Division have retreated from the city. Asayish forces and Zeravani now control Kirkuk city and the surrounding areas."

Yawar pointed out, "Peshmerga forces have thus far not received orders from the President of the Kurdistan Region to move toward the three governorates which are under the control of the Islamic State of Iraq and al-Sham (ISIS)." He added, "There is no need for Peshmerga forces to move into these areas. Iraqi Army forces are no longer present there, and the situation in these areas is highly unstable, as they are under ISIS control."

KRG Spokesperson Minister Safeen Dizayee described the posture of KRG Peshmerga forces. He said, "We are fully committed to the defence of territory administered by the KRG as well as areas of the Kurdistan Region outside of KRG administration." He added, "The KRG is currently a safe haven for approximately 250,000 Syrian refugees as well as hundreds of thousands of internally-displaced people fleeing the violence in Mosul and elsewhere. We are doing our best to cope with this humanitarian emergency."

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No agreement between Nechirvan Barzani and Nouri al-Maliki

Erbil, Kurdistan (KRG.org) – The Eighth Day news agency has issued a story, which has been published by various media outlets, claiming that Prime Minister of the Kurdistan Regional Government Nechirvan Barzani and Iraqi Prime Minister Nouri Maliki have reached an agreement overseen by the United States of America. It is claimed that this agreement entails Iraq allowing the Kurdistan Region to sell oil in return for Peshmerga support in fighting the Islamic State of Iraq and al-Sham (ISIS) in Mosul.

In a statement KRG Spokesperson Minister Safeen Dizayee has refuted this, saying, "This story is completely fabricated and is the furthest thing from the truth. There is no substance to it."

In addition, Minister Dizayee reiterated that the Kurdistan Regional Government and the Peshmerga forces are committed to protecting the security and stability of the Kurdistan Region and the people living inside KRG-administered territory, as well as the areas of Kurdistan outside KRG administration. The KRG will defend them and will not allow them to be targeted or placed under threat in any circumstances.

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Prime Minister Barzani: I ask the people of Kurdistan to support the people of Mosul

Erbil, Kurdistan (KRG.org) – Following the developments in the city of Mosul due to the Iraqi Security Force's inability to maintain security in the city, KRG Prime Minister Nechirvan Barzani has issued the following statement.

"Unfortunately, due to the failure of the Iraqi Security Forces to protect the people and the city of Mosul, the militant group referred to as the Islamic State of Iraq and al-Sham (ISIS) controls the city of Mosul. This has caused widespread fear. The people of Mosul fear for their lives because of attacks and the lack of food and services, and they are leaving their city.

"Over the last two days we tried extremely hard to establish cooperation with the Iraqi Security Forces in order to protect the city of Mosul. Tragically, Baghdad adopted a position which has prevented the establishment of this cooperation.

"In order to assist and support the displaced people of the city of Mosul, including all of the city's different ethnic groups – Kurds, Arabs, Turkmen, Chaldeans and Assyrians – I ask the people of the Kurdistan Region to help the displaced people of Mosul in whatever way they can within the framework of legal and security guidelines. I also urge the United Nations High Commission for Refugees (UNHCR) to provide relief and support for the displaced people fleeing the violence in Mosul.

"In the meantime, we reassure the people living in the areas of Kurdistan outside KRG administration that Kurdish Security Forces and Peshmerga are ready, as always, to handle the security situation in these areas."

– Nechirvan Barzani

Prime Minister of the Kurdistan Region

10 June 2014

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11 Jun 2014

UNHCR responds to massive displacement of Iraqis from Mosul

ERBIL, Iraq, June 11 (UNHCR) –The UN refugee agency said today it was immediately stepping up its aid efforts in Iraq in response to the new massive displacement of people from the northern Iraqi city of Mosul and other areas.

UNHCR protection teams have been on the ground to monitor the outflow and assist those in need, and urgent additional funding is being sought. One protection officer said UNHCR was working to provide shelter, protection and emergency items, including tents to some of the many thousands of people believed to have fled from Iraq's second largest city.

"The needs are immense," said Gemma Woods. "While the numbers of those crossing from Ninewa governorate into Iraq's Kurdistan region today were visibly less than the long line of cars and pedestrians I witnessed yesterday, thousands continue to flee," she added.

The exodus from Mosul, which began earlier this week, follows massive displacement this year in the western Iraqi governorate of Anbar, where fighting since January has forced some half-a-million people to flee the province or seek shelter in safer areas. Local authorities say that as a result of the new outflows from Mosul a further 300,000 additional people have arrived in the past days.

Earlier on Wednesday, UNHCR protection staff monitoring checkpoints between Ninewa governorate and the Kurdistan region, reported that many of those fleeing had no belongings and lacked money for housing, food, water or medical care. They arrive at checkpoints with no idea of where to go next, or how to pay expenses.

UN agencies, humanitarian groups, and government officials are coordinating efforts to do what they can to aid those in need. UN agencies are making an emergency request for additional support for up to half a million additional people as a result of this crisis. Of that, UNHCR is hoping to provide emergency kits, including kitchen and hygiene items, as well as thousands of tents. UNHCR and its partners will also be working to protect and help the displaced.

The protection officer said the situation was less chaotic on Wednesday than Tuesday. "Yesterday it was a wave of humanity, a mass exodus, and those crossing were visibly panicked. They were packed into cars and buses under the harsh sun, and thousands were crossing on foot. Today, the numbers had lessened considerably, but the anxiety was still palpable," she said.

"One family stands out in my mind. There were 12 of them, including a 70 year old grandmother, who had travelled on foot for two days from their farm outside of Mosul. Once they reached the checkpoint, they had no inkling of what they might do next. They were out of money and had nowhere to go," the staff member said.

"These are the most vulnerable; and I saw and spoke with many in 0.0.0.-
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